

Threats to Identification

Most Serious Threat

The most serious threat to identification is selection bias. People who participate in job training may differ systematically from nonparticipants in motivation, job-search intensity, prior labor-market attachment, or access to support networks.

Direction of Bias

The direction of bias is ambiguous. The naive OLS estimate is \$-8,498, while the DML estimate is \$839. If more motivated individuals select into training, the naive estimate may overstate the true effect. If more disadvantaged workers are selected into training, the naive estimate may understate the true effect.

What Data Would Help

Better baseline data would help address this threat. Useful variables would include work history, job-search effort, local labor-market conditions, motivation measures, transportation access, childcare responsibilities, and prior program participation.

Better Research Design

A randomized controlled trial would provide the strongest evidence because treatment assignment would not depend on individual characteristics. If randomization is not possible, a natural experiment, instrumental variable, regression discontinuity design, or difference-in-differences design could strengthen causal identification.

Specification and External Validity

The result may also be sensitive to model specification, sample definition, and functional form. The current analysis uses 16,177 observations, so the result applies most directly to individuals similar to those in the sample. The effect may differ across regions, time periods, industries, and program designs.

Conclusion

The causal claim is credible only if observed controls capture the most important sources of selection into treatment. The DML estimate is \$839 with a 95 percent confidence interval of [\$-556, \$2,235], but the result should still be interpreted cautiously because unobserved confounding may remain.